

Even though fewer women have been admitted to the mental hospital—unlike their male counterparts—many of them do not get discharged. According to experts, this sufficiently exposes the dubious double standards of society where men who remarry after leaving a chronically ill wife in an asylum are not questioned. Indeed, insanity in women leads to greater victimisation. The hospital authorities are slowly coming to terms with reality. “We have now submitted a proposal to the World Health Organisation, seeking financial assistance to set up a half-way home for such abandoned inmates. This will be separate from the hospital where residential facilities will be provided to inmates. We wish to rehabilitate these cured inmates and let them interact with the outside world,” says RINPAS Director Dr A.K. Nag. The National Human Rights Commission has also expressed concern over the abandoned inmates. No tangible solution, however, has been reached.

RINPAS is also home to 37 cured male patients whose families have shown no interest in taking them home. Sixty-four-year-old Om Prakash Verma is one such destitute whose brothers have refused to accept him. Another sexagenarian Bhupendra Baxi, whose address is untraceable, is still lodged with RINPAS 38 years after having fully recovered from schizophrenia. Nageshwar Verma, 72, who according to RINPAS’ records is a resident of Darbhanga,



ONLY 125 OF THE 495 PATIENTS IN RINPAS ARE WOMEN, BUT AS MANY AS 55 OF THEM ARE ON THE ABANDONED LIST

Bihar, has been languishing at the hospital for 50 years. With no family to turn to, such inmates, who have been categorised as “stabilised” by the hospital authorities, are forced to stay among the mentally ill long after their treatment is over. Also, rejection by their own family tends to make some patients unstable despite having recovered. “One such rejected inmate even killed another in a fit of rage. Now he does not smile, only mumbles and has turned a loner,” says a doctor at RINPAS. “When a patient starts recovering, all he wants

is his family's love and care. When he is deprived of it, he goes into depression,” he adds.

Ranjan believes that there are stages in mental illnesses and only those acutely affected need to be hospitalised or kept in an institution. “At later stages of recovery, it is better if the patient lives with his family. If this does not happen over a long period of time, the emotion grows darker. The person reduces interaction, which ultimately results in a cognitive decline,” he explains, adding, “Family support is of crucial significance for total rehabilitation.”

The family perhaps considers the mentally ill a threat and a stigma and there is no optimism about the outcome of medical treatment either. Alarmingly, records at RINPAS suggest that the number of mental cases has witnessed a steep rise in recent years. A few experts attribute this to the breaking family values in society—something which has got magnified in the form of abandoned inmates. ■

“The families are needed most when delusions and hallucinations leave the patients alone. This is the time when most families give up hope and just strike out the inmates from their family albums.”

Dr AMUL RANJAN, Head, Clinical Psychology, RINPAS

